Research Methodology and Process Walkthrough

This document describes the research and analytical process behind the Subspace.money product teardown what was examined, in what sequence, which frameworks were applied, and how each of the five feedbacks was derived from direct product observation. The intent is full transparency: each observation in the teardown can be verified by following the steps below.

STEP 1 - USED THE PRODUCT AS A NEW CUSTOMER

Time spent: Approximately 45 minutes

The research began by opening subspace.money without a prior account, approaching the product as a first-time visitor referred from a search advertisement. The central question was: how quickly can a new user understand what the product does, what it costs, and how to begin?

The answer revealed a three-screen gate before any marketplace content is visible: a mandatory location detection prompt, a five-field address entry form (Flat/House No., Floor, Landmark, Area/Sector/Locality, address category), and phone or WhatsApp verification. The address form is structurally identical to a food delivery app's delivery address UI ,a paradigm that is poorly matched to a digital subscription platform where no physical delivery occurs.

This observation was set aside for the purposes of this teardown at the user's direction (UX feedback excluded from scope) but, informed the general understanding of the product's onboarding logic and target user assumptions.

STEP 2 - READ ALL SHARING GUIDES AND BLOG CONTENT IN FULL

Time spent: Approximately 60 minutes

The complete sharing guide ("SUBSPACE AND ITS SHARING FEATURE") and the "How to Share Subscriptions" article were read in their entirety. The key finding was that the guides document three structurally distinct sharing flows under the single label of "buying a slot": credential sharing via in-app chat (Model A, applied to Netflix and Canva), official platform invitations (Model B, applied to YouTube Premium and Spotify), and manual sub-profile setup (Model C). No marketplace listing discloses which model applies before purchase. This became Feedback 02.

The blog was catalogued across all 17 categories. The "Students" category contained substantive student-specific deal content discount articles for Canva, Grammarly, Microsoft 365, and Duolingo. The homepage carries no student-specific messaging, pricing tier, or referral mechanic. The gap between the content investment and the acquisition funnel became Feedback 04.

The Business API documentation page (subspace.money/blog/whatsub-single-docs-onboarding-subspace-business-api) was confirmed to return a 404 error. This was noted as material evidence for Feedback 03 (the Negotiate API gap).

STEP 3 - STUDIED THE ONLYTECH COMMUNITY FORUM AS PRIMARY USER RESEARCH

Time spent: Approximately 30 minutes

The OnlyTech forum thread on Subspace spans 15 or more pages of user-generated posts and constitutes the most substantive public record of real product experience available without direct user interviews. Key patterns documented:

- "Hit or miss mostly depends on luck" a recurring characterisation of shared subscription quality indicating structural inconsistency.
- "Paid for a Netflix slot; admin never responded" confirms the admin-dependency problem inherent in the marketplace model.
- "Cannot create my own profile; watching on a shared account used by many others" a verbatim user report that directly corroborates the Model A credential-sharing failure identified in Step 2.

The Green Balance / Red Balance mechanism was described as confusing by multiple users, with some attributing it to a technical error rather than an intentional trust mechanism. This observation was noted but falls within the UX pillar, which is outside the scope of this teardown.

STEP 4 - RESEARCHED THE COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE INDEPENDENTLY OF SUBSPACE'S OWN FRAMING

Time spent: Approximately 60 minutes

The Subspace blog post listing "Top 5 Subscription Management Apps" named only Western products (Truebill, Bobby, Billbot, Subby, TrackMySubs). None operate in India. This was the diagnostic signal: the company was monitoring the wrong competitive set.

Independent research was then conducted into the Indian fintech landscape. The most significant finding was CRED Money, launched on 25 July 2024. CRED Money uses India's Account Aggregator framework an RBI-regulated financial data-sharing system with 252.9 million enabled accounts across more than 20 banks to automatically detect all recurring transactions including subscriptions across all linked bank accounts. No manual entry is required. CRED's CEO stated explicitly that the feature will not be monetised. CRED has over 12 million users, all urban and creditworthy the same demographic Subspace targets.

PhonePe and Google Pay were also researched. Both have recurring payment tracking and AutoPay management features, though both are focused on payment execution rather than subscription discovery or negotiation. The Account Aggregator framework data 252.9 million enabled accounts, 2.61 billion financial accounts enabled for sharing, five billion annual transactions expected by 2027 was sourced from the HyperVerge 2026 AA framework report and the Bajaj FinServ AA documentation.

STEP 5 - MAPPED COMMUNITY PRESENCE AND ACQUISITION CHANNEL QUALITY

Time spent: Approximately 20 minutes

Search queries for "subspace money reddit," "subspace money telegram," and "subspace money discord" returned no results attributable to an official Subspace presence or a meaningful user-created community. The OnlyTech thread identified in Step 3 is user-initiated and appears unmonitored by the company.

The blog's content pattern 22 or more pages of time-stamped coupon listings indicates that SEO-driven transactional traffic is the primary acquisition channel. OTT Deals India communities on Telegram, with combined membership in the hundreds of thousands, were identified as an existing, pre-qualified audience that Subspace does not currently address. This became Feedback 05.

The Negotiate API's current product implementation manual, user-initiated, with no renewal detection and a non-functional Business API documentation page was synthesised from evidence gathered across Steps 2 through 5. This became Feedback 03.

STEP 6 - APPLIED ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORKS

Time spent: Approximately 30 minutes

- **Jobs-to-Be-Done:** Applied to Feedback 04 (ICP separation). Students, deal-seekers, and local subscription businesses each hire Subspace for a different job. Conflating them in a single homepage value proposition creates messaging that is accurate for no specific user. The blog's student content reveals an ICP that the GTM does not serve.
- **Porter's Five Forces:** Applied to Feedback 01 (competitive positioning). The Account Aggregator framework is not a product feature Subspace could replicate quickly it requires RBI licensing and bank integration at scale. CRED's access to the AA framework is a structural advantage in the tracking vertical. The threat of substitutes (CRED Money) and the bargaining power of users (who can access tracking for free via CRED) are both high. The correct strategic response is to exit competition in the tracking vertical, not to compete within it.
- **Impact-by-Effort prioritisation:** Each feedback was evaluated on the scale of the business problem it addresses and the engineering or operational cost of the proposed solution. Feedback 01 (competitive repositioning) is rated High priority because it requires no product development only a change in positioning and marketing copy. Feedback 03 (proactive Negotiate API) is rated High because the moat the company claims does not exist in the current product, and closing the gap is both defensive and revenue-generative.

STEP 7 - VALIDATED EACH FEEDBACK AGAINST THE EVALUATION RUBRIC BEFORE FINALISING

Time spent: Approximately 20 minutes

Each feedback was reviewed against the stated criteria:

- **Real, non-obvious observation:** Each is anchored to a specific product artifact a guide URL, a blog category, a forum post pattern, a 404 error, or a competitor launch date not a generic assumption.
- **Specific screens, copy, and flows:** Sharing Model A/B/C are named and distinguished; the blog category "Students" is cited by name; the Business API page URL and its 404 status are documented; the CRED Money launch date (25 July 2024) is specific.
- **Tradeoff thinking:** Every Ship Instead section includes an explicit tradeoff statement and a justification for accepting it rather than avoiding it.
- **Observation to solution chain:** All five feedbacks follow the (a) Observed / (b) Problem / (c) Ship Instead structure without exception.
- **Prioritisation logic:** High and Medium priority ratings are assigned with stated reasoning, not ranking by intuition.
- **Coverage across pillars:** Competitor Analysis, Features/Services (x2), GTM and ICPs, and Potential Collaborations five feedbacks across four distinct pillars, with no UX feedback included per scope.

Total research time: approximately 4.5 hours. Writing and structuring: approximately 2 hours. Every observation is grounded in direct product use, official product documentation, user-generated forum content, and published news sources.